

Certyfikat PMP: Closing the Project

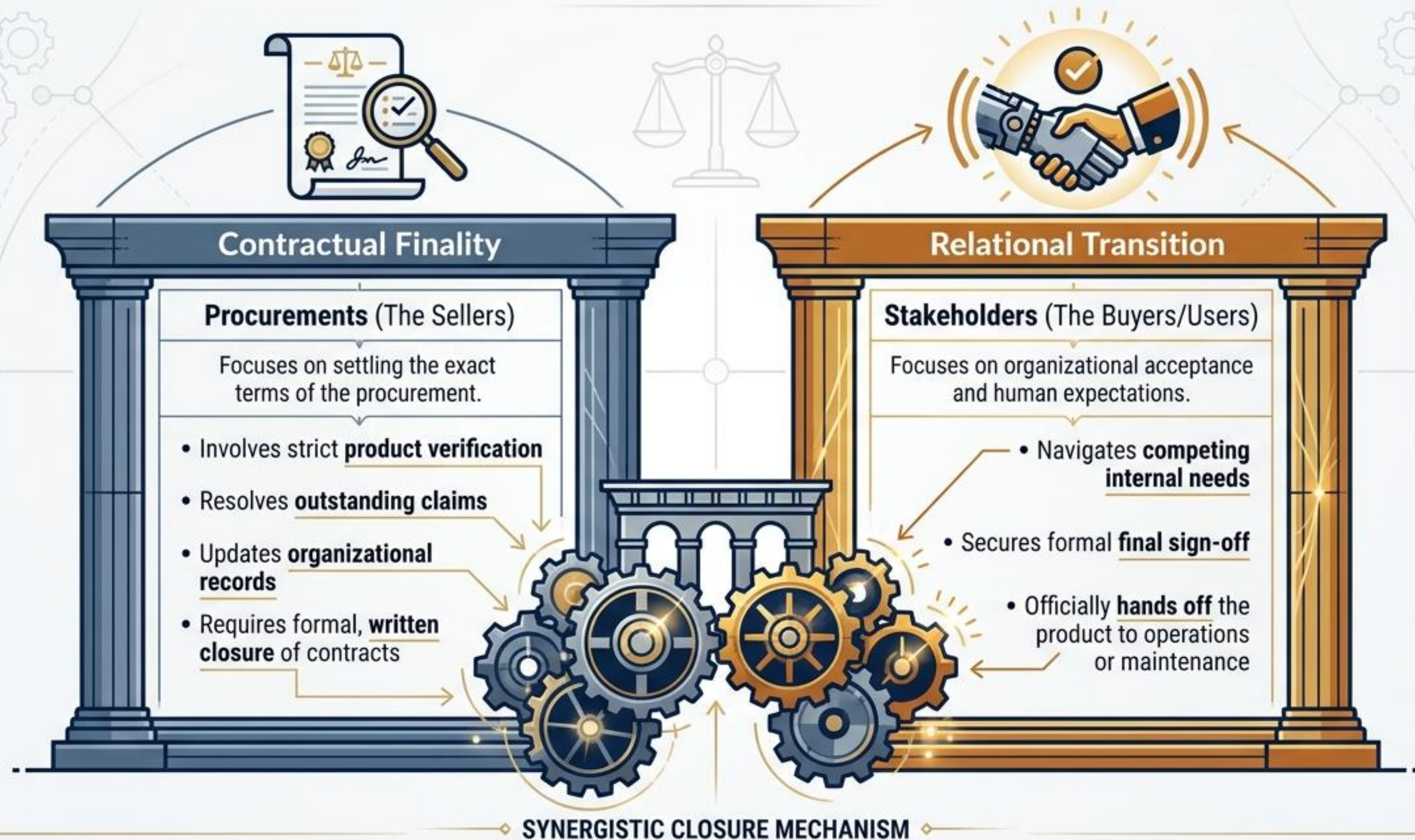


Navigating External Relations, Procurements,
and Stakeholder Transitions

dr Zbigniew Galar

Moving from **execution to legacy**: the strategic art of the **final handshake**.

THE DUAL NATURE OF PROJECT CLOSURE



Demystifying the Verification Triad



Validate Scope

Phase: Monitoring & Controlling

Action: Formal acceptance of specific product deliverables by the customer.

Note: The sign-off document is stored later during closing.



Close Procurements

Phase: Closing

Action: Determines if work performed by a vendor was completed accurately according to the contract.

Note: Only applies to externally contracted work.

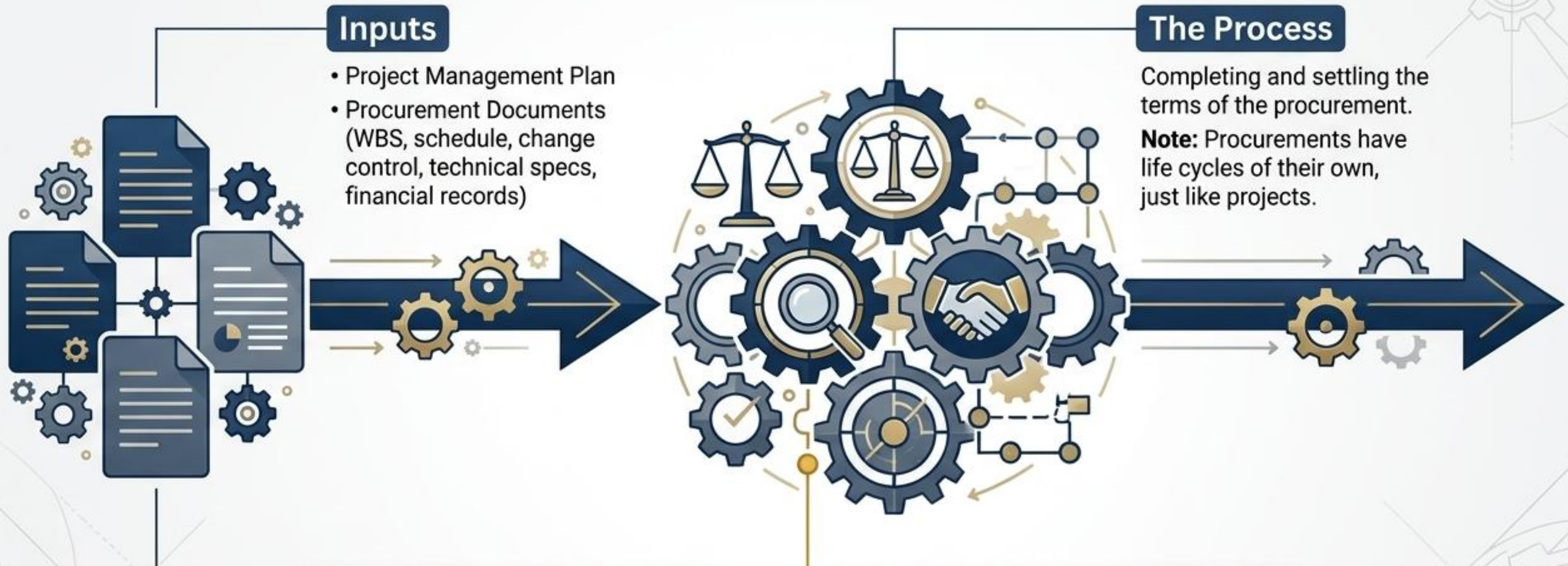


Close Project or Phase

Phase: Closing

Action: Final, overarching verification that all project outcomes are documented, integrated, and officially transferred.

Close Procurements: The Inputs & Mechanics



The Tools of Procurement Closure



1. Procurement Audits

Reviewing the procurement process from initial planning through closure. The goal is to identify flawed procedures and capture successes for use on future organizational projects.



2. Procurement Negotiations

Utilizing Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) techniques. Reaching a negotiated settlement is the most favorable way to resolve disagreements regarding deliverables, claims, or payments.



3. Records Management System

The system used to rigorously index and file all procurement records and supporting documents for future organizational reference.

The Final Outputs of Procurements

Folder 1: Closed Procurements

A formal, written notice provided to the seller stating the contract is complete.

Usually administered by the procurement department, but noted in project records by the PM as proof of finality.

Folder 2: OPA Updates

- Deliverable Acceptance: Formal written notice that deliverables are satisfactory (or rejected and requiring correction).
- Procurement File: The fully indexed compilation of all contract records.
- Lessons Learned: Documentation on vendor performance and process efficiency.

Managing the Post-Acceptance Window



The Warranty Trap

Formal sign-off kicks off the warranty period (e.g., 30-60 days for software).

The Risk: Users often try to disguise new requirements as free bug fixes.

The Defense: Warranties must explicitly spell out exactly what is and isn't covered before closure.



Early Termination Risks

Terminations can occur by agreement, default, or cause.

The Risk: Early termination often results in additional, unexpected charges to the buyer.

The Defense: PMs must rigorously document the specific reasons for early termination in the procurement files.

The Stakeholder Balancing Act at Closure

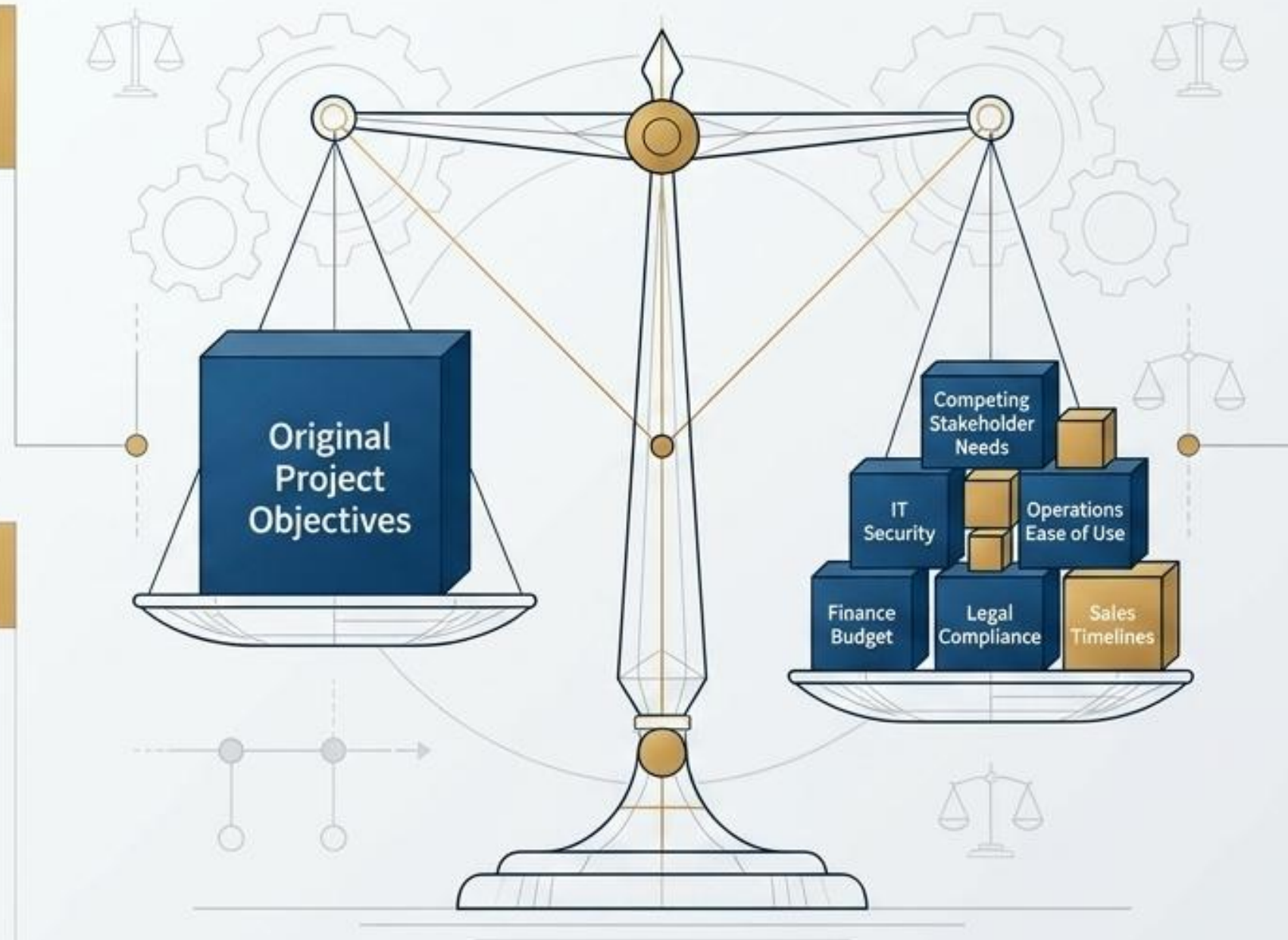
The Reality of Competing Needs

Stakeholders from different departments have conflicting priorities (e.g., IT's need for strict system security vs. Operations' need for frictionless ease of use).

The PM's Defense

Prioritize competing needs strictly against the original project objectives.

Redefining scope during the closing phase is rarely an option.



Communication Translation

The PM must translate complex technical problems into simple, actionable explanations for non-technical stakeholders (e.g., explaining IT architecture limitations to Finance without relying on jargon).

Defending the Triple Constraint



Real World Scenario

1

The Scenario:

A Sponsor requests a complex geographic mapping addition (GIS) built internally by the project team at the last minute.

2

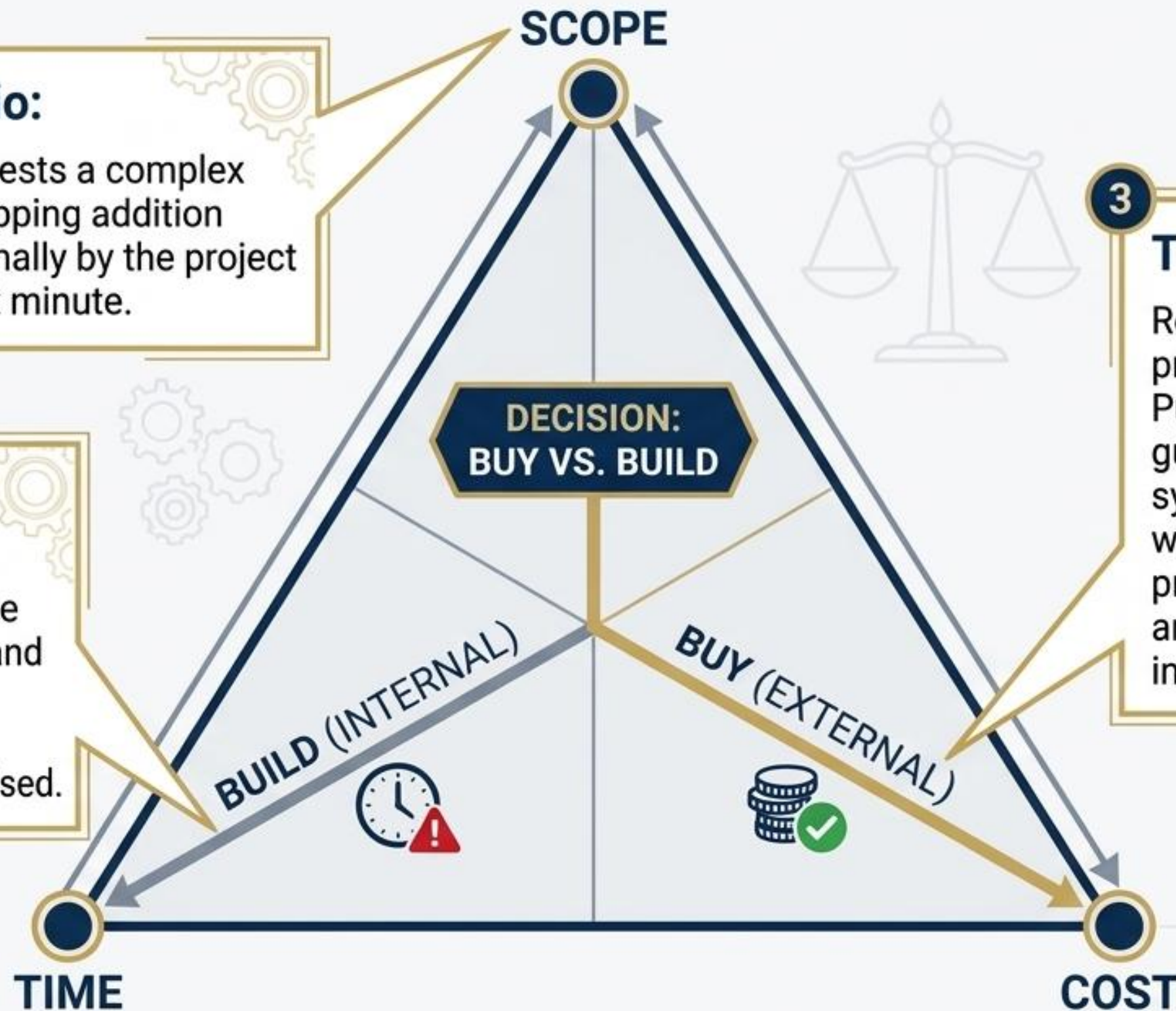
The Threat:

Building internally risks a massive delay because the team lacks GIS expertise, and existing address data is unstandardized. Time becomes heavily compromised.

3

The Defense:

Recommend external vendor procurement ('Buy'). Purchasing software guarantees the system is operational in weeks rather than years, protecting the schedule and quality despite immediate software costs.



Extracting the Gold: Lessons Learned

Successes

The successes of the team

Failures, Unplanned Risks, Avoidable Mistakes

The Deep Data (Below the Surface)

True value comes from documenting the reasons the reasons for corrective actions, the causes of performance variances, unplanned risks that materialized, and avoided mistakes.

The Barrier: Most PMs skip this step because employees fear associating their names with mistakes or failed projects.

The Cultural Solution: Management must create an atmosphere of trust where lessons are framed as organizational assets, not reprimands.



Audits vs. Lessons Learned

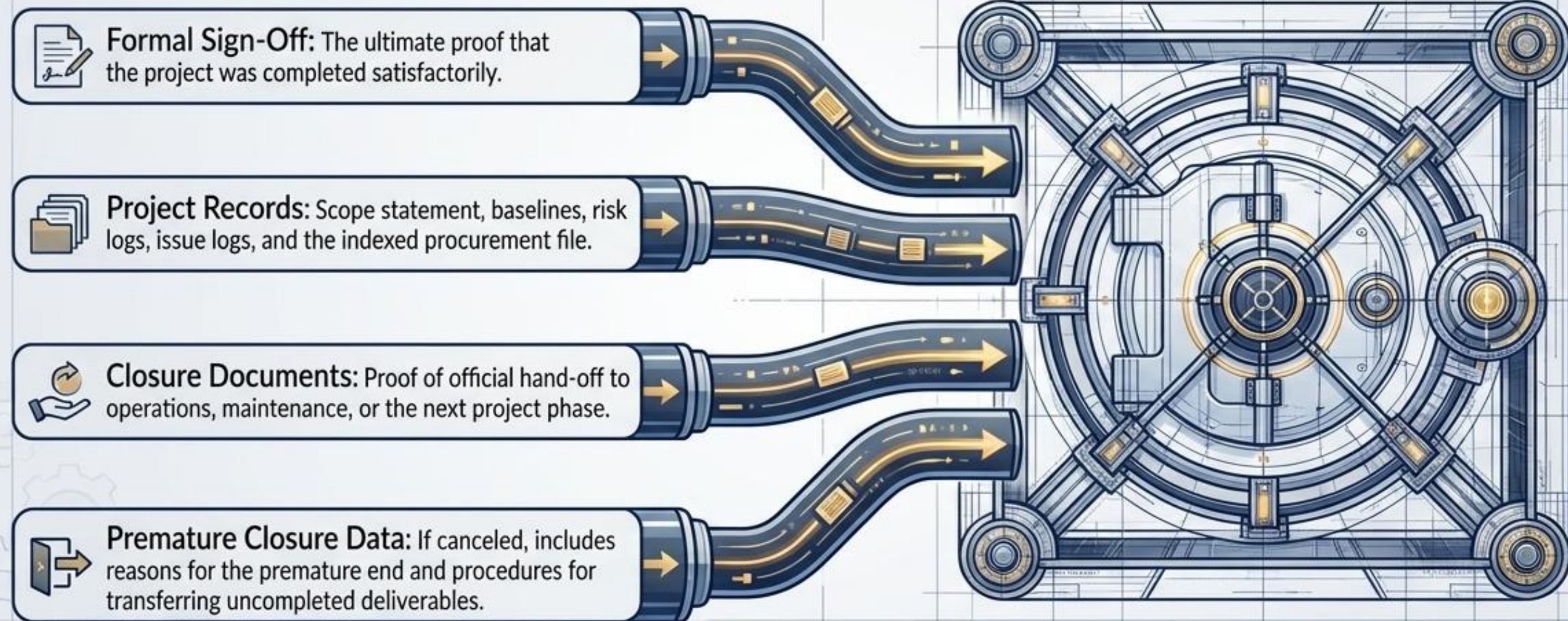
Lessons Learned Sessions

- Team-driven and experiential.
- Focuses on specific tactical improvements and team dynamics.
- Requires profound honesty to capture the “good, the bad, and the ugly” to evolve company culture.

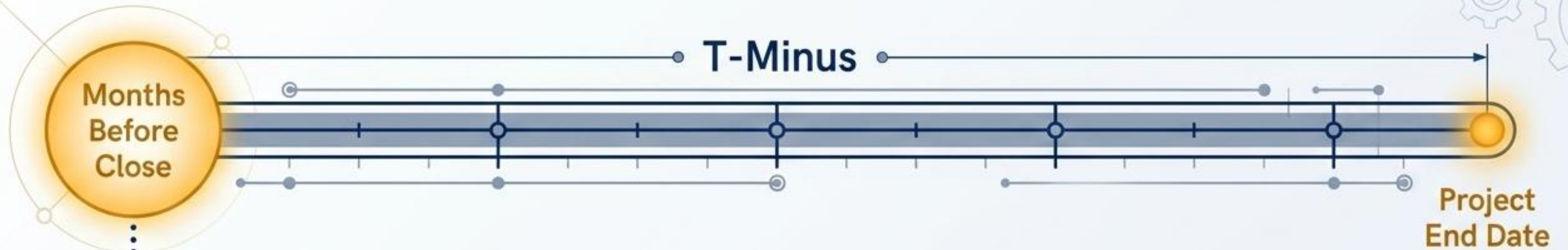
Post-Implementation Audits

- Evaluative and objective.
- Examines the project from beginning to end to verify if the product satisfied the initial business objectives.
- Often used by organizations instead of lessons learned (not an official PMBOK output, but a strong best practice).

Archiving: Organizational Process Assets (OPA) Updates



Releasing the Team (The Internal-External Transition)

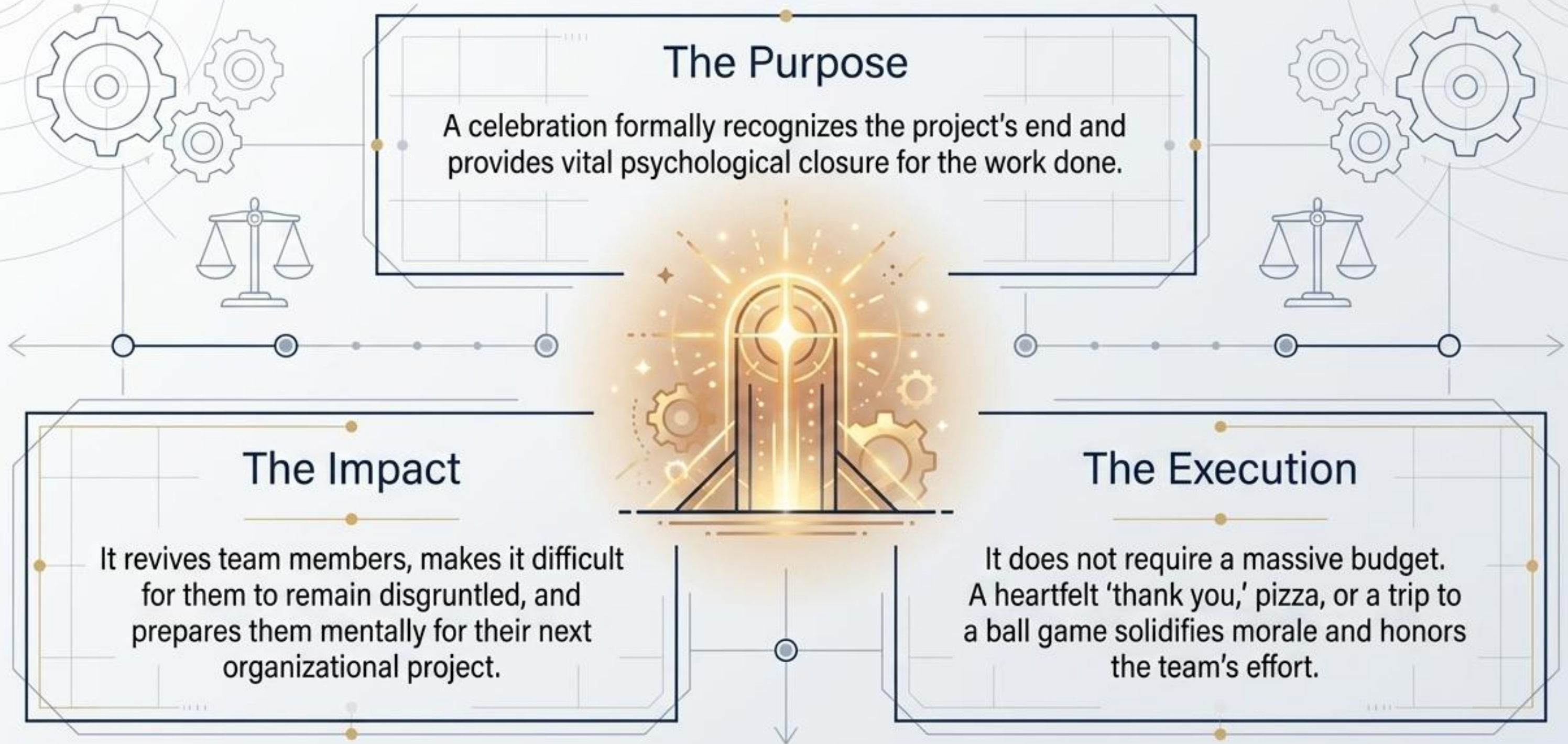


The Matrix Reality: Releasing team members is not an official PMBOK process, but it is a critical PM duty. In matrix organizations, team members must return to functional managers or transition to new external projects.

Proactive Scheduling: The PM must notify functional managers **months in advance** of the project close.

The Impact: This lead time allows functional managers to adequately plan activities and schedule resource dates, preventing costly organizational downtime.

The Psychology of Celebration



The Perfect Close



The Ecosystem of Closure

A flawless project close leaves vendors legally settled, stakeholders satisfied with the deliverables, the organization smarter through archived knowledge, and the team psychologically recognized.

A great project manager doesn't just deliver the product; they curate the legacy. — dr Zbigniew Galar